Pivotum

THE DEGREE RISK INDEX · FALL 2026 EDITION

So you're thinking about architecture

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI.

Licensed architecture: **5.0** out of 10 — mid-range, and reasonably protected.

Production drafting: **7.6**.

But honestly, AI isn't the main thing you should be thinking about with this one. The real question is the length of the path, and whether you've looked at what's next to it.

The 60-second version

- The licensed end is protected — the stamp is a legal monopoly and clients want a human answerable.
- It takes eight to thirteen years from starting school to being licensed.
- The pay doesn't match that length. Construction managers and engineers get there faster for similar money.
- **Getting licensed adds 18–35% to your salary.** It's the whole point of the path.
- And the data centre boom is creating architectural demand — the biggest specialisation premium in the field.

Why the licensed end holds up

All fifty states require architects to be licensed, and certain drawings must be signed by one, with personal liability attached. No amount of AI capability transfers legal liability — that's a law thing, not a technology thing.

Site work can't be done remotely. Visits, commissioning, inspection, snagging — reading what's actually there against what the drawings claim. That's why construction administration scores best in the whole profession at **4.7**.

And every site is genuinely new. Different ground, different client, different code, different contractor. The combination has no precedent even when every individual piece does.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Construction administration / site	4.7
Licensed architect / design lead	5.0
Specialist (sustainability, computational)	5.5
Technical / BIM coordination	6.7
Production drafting	7.6

Same split as everywhere in our index: the site holds, the desk drifts.

And you can see it in the pay too. 2D CAD drafters average $48,000–$58,000 and the role is shrinking as firms move to full BIM. BIM technicians with a few years of experience get $58,000–$78,000, because demand exceeds supply.

Even inside the exposed tier, the split is between operating a tool and understanding a model.

The part we won't soften

Architecture takes the longest path to licensure of any design profession, and the pay doesn't match.

- **Eight to thirteen years** from starting school to being licensed
- Five-year B.Arch, then the AXP experience requirement, then six exam divisions
- Most people take 18–30 months just to pass the exams, costing $1,500–$2,000 in fees
- Median architect pay is around **$99,270**

Now the uncomfortable comparison. **Construction managers and engineers reach broadly similar salaries by considerably shorter routes** — and in our index they score better too: construction management **3.3**, licensed engineering **4.0**, architecture **5.0**.

Shorter path. Better protection. Comparable money.

That's not a reason not to do architecture. It's a reason to do it because you want *this work*, not because of what it pays. On pay alone, the neighbours win.

Two other honest things:

Most of your first decade is technical documentation, not design. Only senior designers and principals spend most of their time on creative work. That surprises people.

And deadline weeks run 50–70 hours.

The one number that matters most

Getting licensed adds 18–35% to your salary.

The AIA's compensation report — covering over 13,000 positions across 817 firms — found unlicensed professionals in their first five years earn roughly $52,000–$78,000. Licensed, that jumps to $78,000–$105,000.

It's the single biggest salary decision in the profession.

And the licensure pipeline has been *shrinking*, which has pushed licensed salaries up faster in the last two years than in most of the previous decade. Scarcity at the licensed end is real.

So: commit to the licence, or don't start. Everything about this career points at it.

Where the money actually is

Specialisation pays sharply here, more than most people realise:

- **Data centre and laboratory design: 20–35% premium** — the AI buildout creating architectural demand, the same way it's creating electrical demand
- Healthcare architecture: 18–30%
- Sustainable and net-zero design: 15–25%

Worth knowing early, because these are choices you make during the degree rather than after.

The open question nobody's answered

Something the profession hasn't worked out, and we'd rather tell you than pretend.

Getting licensed requires logged experience hours under a licensed architect. That's genuinely protective — firms *have* to employ and supervise candidates, which keeps the entry route open.

But what you do during those hours has changed. If you spend them directing generative tools and checking output, you log the same hours as someone who spent them drafting by hand. Are you building the same judgment?

Nobody knows. The licence certifies you did the time and assumes the time teaches.

This hits architecture harder than accounting or engineering, because more of the traditional AXP was drafting — and drafting is exactly what's automating.

Practical response: seek out the work that's genuinely hard rather than the work that's fast, and get site exposure specifically.

Does this actually sound like you?

Architecture suits people who:

- **Want to make things that persist.** Buildings stand for decades and people live inside them. That's the reason people stay.
- **Can hold a long horizon** — the creative work arrives around year eight to twelve
- **Enjoy constraint** — code, budget, physics, client. Design inside hard limits.
- **Can coordinate people who disagree** — engineers, contractors, planners, clients
- **Can take criticism of work they care about**

Harder if you expect creative work early, need strong early earnings, or dislike documentation and regulation — which is most of the first few years.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **Accreditation for licensure** where you intend to practise. Non-negotiable — check directly.
- **What proportion of graduates are licensed within five years?** The number that matters and the one nobody publishes. Ask.
- **Is there real site exposure**, not just studio and office placement?

- **Building science and computational design depth** — those are the specialist tracks that pay
- **Is the studio teaching design judgment or software?** A curriculum organised around tools is training you for the exposed tier.

Two things worth doing

Visit a construction site, not just a building. The gap between what's drawn and what actually gets built is the profession, and an afternoon there will tell you whether it appeals.

Then find an architect five to ten years in and ask what they do all day, and how long licensure actually took them. Ask someone who'll be straight rather than encouraging.

One comparison worth making properly

Construction management. Scores 3.3 — better than architecture. Shorter path. Chronically short of people. And you can come up through a trade or a degree.

Civil or structural engineering. Scores 4.0. Similar money, shorter route, stronger licence.

Neither of those is a consolation prize. If what you love is buildings existing rather than buildings being designed, one of them may fit better — and it's worth an hour of honest thinking before you commit to the longest path in design.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- Architects — Occupational Outlook Handbook — government data on pay, growth and licensure. Then read the **Construction Managers** and **Civil Engineers** pages next to it. That comparison is the most useful twenty minutes here.
- NCARB — the licensure authority. AXP and exam requirements, timelines and real costs, from the source rather than a prospectus.
- How long does it take to become an architect? — a clear breakdown of the eight-to-thirteen-year path and what each stage costs.

There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.